if invasion were imminent, the first stage would have to be a blockade of the island.

McNamara proposed blockade as an “appropriate action” in its own right. “If we do it then, why would we not do it today?” he asked the gathering. He had not finished his thought when the president cut him short, saying: “The reason we don’t is that, is because we figure that they may try to blockade Berlin and we would then try to blockade Cuba.” He wanted to keep the threat of blockading Cuba as leverage against Khrushchev’s actions in Berlin. He also thought that a blockade of Cuba “would not do them that much harm for quite a while.” Kennedy’s intervention shot down the idea of a blockade before it was fully developed and had a chance to gain support in the room.

McNamara would not raise the blockade issue again that day. Instead, he came back with a different strategy, pushing for the mobilization of reserves—a step needed to prepare not only a blockade but also an invasion of Cuba. He also saw it as a means of appeasing and calming Congress: “If the leadership wants to act in relation to Cuba, one of the best actions I can think of is exactly this.” Sending a message to Khrushchev while appeasing Congress—Kennedy was sold on McNamara’s idea right away. He wanted the statement as soon as possible. “We can’t permit somebody to break this story before we do,” he told his aides at the start of the meeting.[20]

On the evening of September 4, the White House press secretary, Pierre Salinger, finally released a presidential statement on Cuba to the media. “Information has reached this Government in the last four days from a variety of sources which establishes without doubt that the Soviets have provided the Cuban Government with a number of anti-aircraft defense missiles,” read the statement. Its final version included neither Kennedy’s pledge not to invade Cuba nor his promises to defend the sanctity of the Monroe Doctrine, which had appeared in the original drafts. Instead it proposed to treat the “Cuban question” as “part of the worldwide challenge posed by Communist threats to peace.” The president issued a threat not against the USSR but against Cuba. “It continues to be the policy of the United States that the Castro regime will not be allowed to export its aggressive purposes by force or the threat of force,” read the statement. “It